

Rise of the DROW

CAMPAIGN PRIMER



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WELCOME TRAVELER! This guide contains all the information a player needs to orient themselves to the Aventyr campaign setting and to the *Rise of the Drow* series of adventures, whether the game begins on the surface in Rybalka or in the Underworld. The adventure focuses on thwarting a drow war of aggression, but the book itself contains the tools to run a sandbox-style campaign in the Underworld, particularly focused around Embla Holoth, and the Fungi Forest. Exploring the Underworld – itself a dangerous prospect – allows the GM to introduce any number of unique locations. To get the most out of a campaign of this style, your GM may decide to include optional resources to accompany this guide: *Underworld Races & Classes*, and *Occult Secrets of the Underworld*, but these books are not required to enjoy the *Rise of the Drow*.

RYBALKA, HEART OF THE FRONTIER

RYBALKA IS A LAKE-SIDE, FRONTIER VILLAGE. Even if your character is not from Rybalka or a nearby region, they have at least traveled here at the start of the adventure, and thus, whether through the local scuttlebutt or from careful observation, they have likely learned something of the village.

The Rybalkan Peninsula on Serpent Lake is an isolated place. Numerous tombs and barrows of Vikmordere origin can be found on the Rybalkan Peninsula and throughout the Vikmordere Valley, as well as ruined fortresses from the region's long history of conflict.

Rybalka itself sits in a sheltered cove on the peninsula's southern shore, protecting the village from the worst of the weather from both the lake and the mountains to the north. Two roads lead away from Rybalka, both in a northerly

direction: one toward the Dark Wood and the pass through the mountains, and the other to the nearby iron mine.

In the past, Vikmordere raiders used the strategic location of the fishing village as a launching point for attacks against the Klavek Kingdom. The Klavek monarchy moved troops into the valley and launched an arduous assault against the Vikmordere in hopes of securing the village and the lucrative iron mine. After many failed attempts and the deaths of hundreds, the Klavek Kingdom was finally able to oust the Vikmordere raiders and take control of the village.

Rybalka is on the far frontier of the Klavek Kingdom, but retains its traditional Vikmordere roots. Culturally, the villagers are birthing the first generation of what's becoming known as "Rybalkans" – those with both Klavek and Vikmordere lineage. While the influence of both cultures can still be felt, increasingly they are becoming more accepting and tolerant of each other, rather than clinging to a past that serves no one.

Mayor Igor Leonid is the Klavek-born trustee appointed to rule over Rybalka. He commands a small contingent of Klavek soldiers to this end. He has embraced frontier life, encouraging his fellow Klavek immigrants to do the same. For this reason he is well-liked by almost all Rybalka's citizens, Klavek and Vikmordere alike.

The dominant religion in the frontier village is a unique blend of traditional Vikmordere practices drawn from worship of the Ancestor Spirit and the rigorous doctrines of the Axiomatic General, a deity of note in the Klavek Kingdom. The Cathedral at Rybalka is a multi-faith temple, overseen by High Priest Juriendor, himself a follower of the Axiomatic General, though he incorporates numerous Vikmordere traditions into his ceremonies.

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Village of RYBALKA

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1. Lookout Walk
 2. Thirsty Serpent Tavern
 3. Sulwotik's Spirits
 4. West Fold Lumber Mill
 5. Bugg Odds & Inn
 6. Shipwright's Guildhall
 7. Fishauler's Consortium
 8. Rybalkan Mine Guildhall
 9. Mastera Library
 10. Town Hall & Barracks
 11. Hopeful Signs
 12. Vickruck's Root Cellar
 13. Carolyn's Baked Goods
 14. Rybalka Lodge
 15. Quorron's Forge
 16. Rybalka Cathedral & The North Road

UPPERWORLD RACES

Your GM will inform you of your game's specifics regarding the various races and cultures, as well as their societal habits and relationships with each other, but the following presents the defaults assumed by the Aventyr campaign setting.

HUMANS

Humans are the overwhelming majority in Rybalka and the surrounding regions. Humans who hail from the Klavek Kingdom are the more recent emigrants. They often clash with the region's ancestral inhabitants, the Vikmordere.

The Klavek Kingdom is perhaps more accurately described as an empire, controlling vast lands and resources. The frontier of this empire extends into the Vikmordere Valley and the shores of Serpent Lake in the form of the recently conquered Rybalka. With this sole acquisition, the Klavek Kingdom nearly doubled its ability to produce iron, thanks to the village's nearby mine.

Once a Vikmordere settlement of fishermen and shipwrights, when the iron mine was discovered Rybalka was thrust into regional importance. Countless Vikmordere tribes vied for control of the village, using it as a staging ground for raids, against both other tribes and upriver Klavek settlements. After a generation of conflict, the village now sits firmly under Klavek control, though its future remains uncertain should the disparate Vikmordere tribes find common cause against the Klavek Kingdom.

DWARVES

Dwarves are rare outside of their fortress cities beneath the earth, but they are known throughout the Upperworld as smiths and craftsmen of great skill. Those dwarves that have made their way to the surface speak longingly of crystal caverns and mushroom ale, and they'll be quick to remind any who will listen that "dweorg" is their race's true name, lest you

confuse them with their dark cousins. The dwarven settlement that is nearest Rybalka is the city of Embla, a hub of trade and a cultural melting pot in the Underworld.

ELVES

Elves in human lands are generally considered spies, and looked upon with great suspicion. Most adopt simple disguises when interacting with humans, and rarely enter a human settlement without a clear plan of escape.

The majority of elves live within the protective confines of the Silent Forest to the south of the Klavek Kingdom.

GNOMES

The country of Pradjna—leagues to the west of the Klavek Kingdom—is the only country on the continent which can be said to have a population of gnomes. Studious, inventive, and curious of all things technological, these gnomes are well-traveled in their search for inspiration for their next breakthrough.

Elsewhere, particularly in secluded forests that have never known a woodcutter's axe, one can find small gnomish villages. But these "gnomes," if they can be called that, are more elfish in appearance and behavior than their spanner-wielding cousins.

HALFLING

Halflings bear scant trust for the other races of Aventyr, especially humans, whom they view as feckless and faithless. This is perhaps due to the race's long history of tragedy. Their once fertile and populous lands in the far Sothron Sea stand mostly empty in the wake of generational wars with alien invaders. Since then, the island nation has grown even more insular.

HALF-ELVES

Half-elves, the rarest of all civilized races in the Klavek Kingdom, are treated as elves in nearly every regard. Like elves, a half-elf quickly learns to hide their appearance in order to avoid persecution,

though the disguise needed is often as simple as wearing a hood and growing a beard.

HALF-ORC

Half-orcs are generally distrusted by humans and looked upon with a mixture of pity and fear. In the Vikmordere Valley, however, bravery, skill of the hunt, and combat prowess are prized more than they are elsewhere in human lands, and a half-orc who is able to prove themselves a capable warrior often finds human settlements tolerant of their presence.

UNDERWORLD CITIES:

EMBLA & STONEHOLME

WHETHER YOUR CHARACTER CALLS EMBLA HOME OR HAS TRAVELED FROM DEEP IN THE UNDERWORLD, ANYONE WHO HAS HEARD OF THE TRADE CITY AND ITS SURROUNDS KNOWS THESE TRUTHS THROUGH NAUGHT MORE THAN CONVERSATION AND AWARENESS. Stoneholme, too, is a place of storied reputation, even if few outsiders have a first-hand knowledge of the ancient city. Here follows an overview of these two cities that serves as an introduction to the Underworld of Aventyr.

All of the Underworld is full of dangers, not only from its denizens and more nefarious inhabitants, but from the terrain itself. Most travelers stick to known roadways and hire guides and guards to protect them on the way. A handful of settlements stand as bastions against the seemingly endless tide of darkness. Embla is the largest and most well-known of these. It was founded as an outpost of Stoneholme in the ancient past. Today, the sister cities are quite opposite in their approach to life in the Underworld.

Embla gets its moniker, the City of Lights, from its bright crystal gonjolas—hanging buildings interconnected with chain-suspended walkways—that dominate the city heights. From these gonjolas the dwarven merchant clans rule over the bustling trade city. The Merchant